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Nature and Spirit in the Renaissance

Was There a Renaissance?

Abrupt historical transitions exist far more frequently in the historian's mind than in the world of events. At the same time, we have observed that dramatic alterations in perspective do occur and that these have occasionally taken place on a relatively large scale. Two ready illustrations are to be found between the Augustan period of Rome and the seventh century, and between the Homeric period of Greek history and the Age of Pericles. A more recent, equally vivid change in perspective occurred in far less time: that between the early empire of Charlemagne and the philosophical revival of the twelfth century.

In comparing the members of any one of these apposed pairs, one is struck by the degree and number of differences in institutions, social organizations, political processes, aesthetic productions, and philosophical and psychological inclinations. This makes it all the more surprising that most general histories focus on the Renaissance and accord to it a status rare in the annals of historical analysis. It is a focus or emphasis that tempts the more critical reader or writer to overcompensate by denying anything original to the period. But this is a compensation well worth avoiding. Undoubtedly the Renaissance that flowered in Florence in the fifteenth century and spread throughout Europe by the sixteenth is a period of change, and the changes it brought either touched or completely altered the full range of existing social and political institutions. The medieval town gave way to the Renaissance city. Chivalry disappeared and patronage took its place. The scholarship of devotion gradually relinquished first place to humanistic studies and halting steps toward the natural sciences. The full partnership of Church and State became more competitive, occasionally combative. Secular authority grew, and economics came to challenge theology as the State's first science.

When scholars and aesthetes of the nineteenth century invented the term,

they did not intend "renaissance" to imply a mere development of trends already in place in medieval Europe. Writers such as Walter Pater, T. A. Trollope, and John Ruskin sought to convey the notion of a rebirth and, specifically, of a rebirth of the classical approach to life. We need not cavil with this Victorian usage, for, although the nineteenth century created the term, it was the Renaissance scholars themselves who insisted that they were in fact re-creating the classical outlook. But what is to be made of such a claim? In asserting their role as new classicists committed to restoring a particular set of values and institutions, the spokesmen of the Renaissance clearly regarded themselves within a historical context. They rejected what they considered to be the perspective of their immediate predecessors. More than this, however, they recognized the evolutionary nature of the human condition, which is, after all, what a historical perspective entails. These very claims served notice on the medieval view of man and society, the view of eternal order with each person in his intended place.

Was there a Renaissance? If the term is to signify a renewed commitment to a contemplative and philosophical life, there surely was no Renaissance in Europe between 1350 and 1600. If it is meant to convey a renewed appreciation of the classical works, and especially the classical philosophical treatises, we need only recall that Lorenzo Valla (1405–1457), perhaps the period's most celebrated philosopher, was passionately contemptuous of very nearly every Greek and Roman thinker, with the possible exception of Epicurus.¹ Ficino's neo-Platonist "Academy" in Florence (established through the support of Cosimo de Medici), as well as Pietro Pomponazzi's Aristotelianism are sufficient in themselves to confirm the interest of Renaissance scholars in ancient philosophy. But, in light of the feverish philosophizing that took place from the eleventh to the thirteenth centuries, this interest can hardly be called a revival! Moreover, the growth of trade, the establishment of banking agencies, the undertaking of massive public and religious works, all are features of the Renaissance but are by no means sudden in their appearance. Each can be traced, uninterruptedly, to Charlemagne, to the Ottonian monarchy of Germany, to the Lombards in Italy, and to the Norman kings in France. By the time of the Renaissance, each had attained a certain stability and centrality, but none was new.

If one is to adopt the term, therefore—and it is one so grafted to the historian's lexicon that no argument will succeed in removing it—we inevitably impute features that were not unique to the period. It would be sounder to acknowledge that something was born, not reborn, in that period, and there is a theme in Renaissance literature that for all intents and purposes really is quite new to the world of letters, one that could scarcely have found approval in Plato's Academy or the Lyceum or the court of Marcus Aurelius. As expressed in the Renaissance, it is a theme that would not have been approved even in the

universities of the Schoolmen (Scholastics). It is the theme of *the dignity of man*, with the associated insistence that *the world was made for human beings, more or less to do with as they will*. Perhaps there is no clearer expression of the view than these lines from Marsilio Ficino in 1474:

Universal providence belongs to God who is the universal cause. Hence, man, who provides generally for all things, both living and lifeless, is a *kind* of god. . . . Man alone abounds in such a perfection that he first rules himself, something that no animals do, and thereafter rules the family, administers the state, governs nations, and rules the whole world. As if he were born to rule, he is unable to endure any kind of slavery. Moreover, he undergoes death for the common weal, a thing which no animal does. . . . [O]ur soul will sometime be able to become in a sense all things; and even to become a god.²

Humanism, Individualism, and the Renaissance City

Our present age, which, more than ever before, finds the public commitment to improve the lot of the less fortunate ranking near the top on the list of the affairs of state, tends to lull us into thinking that humanism has always referred to humaneness. Also, living as we do in an intellectual and cultural period in which religious orthodoxy and power are in scarce supply, there is a tendency to think of humanism as something of an anti-religionism and to assume, thereby, that the humanism of the Renaissance was a movement away from the Church. These notions are false. *The humanism of the Renaissance is inconceivable without Christianity, but in no case is it to be confused with altruism, charity, or a widespread dedication to the welfare of the unfortunate.* It was first and foremost *a new individualism of the rugged sort*. Earlier ages hosted heroic epics in which finely crafted personalities appear, but the Renaissance conception of the person and of what we call "personality" was different. *In the Renaissance, personality is taken to be protean and organic, evolving as a result of changing conditions, and taking on a fixed form only when the individual has settled on a position in society and has essentially chosen a form of life for himself.* Just as it is no longer assumed that the occupation of one's father determines the future course of one's working life, it is, increasingly, no longer assumed that one's origins bear determinatively on the balance of one's life. There is a new perspective on human nature, and a *new place* created for its development: *the city.*

The city was surely one of the great achievements of the Renaissance. Florence, the quintessential Renaissance city of the fifteenth century, was chiefly the creation of the Medicis, whose genius for finance was undiminished from the time of Cosimo the Elder (1389–1464) to Cosimo the Great (1519–1574). Not content with remaking the economic and architectural face of Italy, this family covered all its bets by siring two popes, Leo X and Clement VII. More

than great kings and merchants, however, it was the Renaissance city itself that sustained the growing sense of individualism and its limitless possibilities. The medieval town had room for but a handful of leading figures. The Holy Roman Empire, like all empires, was of a scale to embarrass all but regal initiative or papal intervention. The city, however, was perfectly suited to the fierce economic and cultural competition that yields visible and often sudden heroes, and sudden reversals of fortune. It affords anonymity when needed, celebrity when earned.

This capacity of urban life to nurture individual excellence was recognized clearly by the luminaries of the Renaissance. Early in the fifteenth century, Leonardo Bruni, the chancellor of Florence, wrote his *History of the Florentines* in which he attributed much of the success of the city to the fact that it did not labor under the stultifying and regulatory influences of a Roman empire, or an empire of any sort. Charmed by Aristotle's *Politics* and Plato's *Republic*, Bruni led his contemporaries to a reverence for their cities and a commitment to attain the greatness that only urban life allows.³ Bruni's praise of the city and the very Renaissance idea of the city was rooted in the conviction that we are born for a life of civility and cultivation, and the best of us for something bordering on the divine.

If the spirit of humanism was individualism, the term itself was intended to describe only the intellectual pursuits held proper for enlightened members of the urban centers of Italy. These pursuits revolved around the venerable humane letters (*litterae humaniores*), or "humanities," as they are now called. The subjects comprising this domain were the Greek and Latin classics, though Renaissance scholars were not much for careful, philosophical analysis, let alone philosophical originality. Renaissance humanism, then, was neither self-consciously humane nor, in any modern sense, especially humanitarian. When the first graduated tax was introduced in Florence, intended to provide relief for the poor, the affluent Florentines were stubborn in their opposition. The humanistic movement, if it may thus be called, evolved from and was something of the concluding state of chivalry through which the privileged classes might work toward noble and honorable ends. As an intellectual movement, humanism was devoted to a broader range and a different type of classical scholarship than that which had caught the attention of the Scholastics. As a moral instrument, it was intended (or at least used) to protect the cultural, artistic, and intellectual prerogatives of aristocrats and the circles that formed around them.

Petrarch (1304–1374)

The great Petrarch, called by more than one historian the very father of the Renaissance, goes to some lengths, in an essay entitled *On His Own Ignorance and That of Many Others*,⁴ to prove the weaknesses and contradictions of those

vaunted Greeks and Romans. Commenting on Aristotle's treatment of happiness in his ethical works, Petrarch offers this, which is enough to convey the flavor of his rebukes:

He knew so absolutely nothing of true happiness that any pious old woman, any faithful fisherman, shepherd or peasant is—I will not say more subtle, but happier in recognizing it. . . . He saw happiness as much as the night owl does the sun.⁵

It is passages such as this that sharply distinguish the painstaking analytical efforts of the Scholastics and the larger agendas the Renaissance commentators were prosecuting.

No single work of Petrarch's stands as a psychological treatise, nor, for that matter, does the bulk of his scholarship qualify as philosophy. Like Voltaire after him and Diogenes before, his position within the most important intellectual movement of his age was earned more by the daily effect of his letters, his immediate effect on his friends, his influence among political and financial luminaries, and his winning rebukes of those who might stand in the way of progress, even if they were drawn from the ranks of Aristotelians. His "book" on his own ignorance was really a long letter to his friend Donato. In it he attacks the aloof rationality of Aristotle with a poet's passion, insisting that man can be happy only when in possession of faith and immortality, two properties conspicuously absent in Aristotle's treatises on *eudaimonia*.⁶ Petrarch's own authorities are the Bible, St. Augustine, and Cicero, not to mention fishermen and pious old women. He rejects Aristotle not because the philosopher was wrong (which, by Petrarch's lights, he was), but because philosophy itself, and especially Aristotle's, failed to make men either good or happy.

It is one thing to know, another to love; one thing to understand, another to will.⁷

We find here and elsewhere in Petrarch one of the principal elements of Renaissance thought, a skepticism toward intellectualism. Note that this is not a religious skepticism. Quite the contrary. Petrarch was concerned to re-create a healthier and purer climate of faith, one not cloudy with Scholastic analysis. He saw his opponents in the camp of the Aristotelians, whose contempt for Plato caused them either to ridicule Christian belief or to insist that such belief be reconciled with the tenets of logic. The opposition, then, was none other than medieval philosophy. By the fourteenth century, Scholasticism had invited many quasi-heretical factions who found the Aristotelian system congenial to the coy badinage the skeptic so readily heaps on those of simple faith and little learning. We should be less surprised, then, to learn that Petrarch, this father of Renaissance humanism, comes down emphatically against, of all things, freedom of speech:

So sweet does the word Freedom sound to everyone that Temerity and Audacity please the vulgar crowd, because they look so much like Freedom. Thus the night owls insult the eagle with impunity.⁸

And here is still another characteristic that will be present in so much of the thought of the age: suspicion, even hostility toward philosophical speculation and a reserved position on intellectual freedom. Petrarch and his contemporaries were of a decidedly practical disposition. The worth of a person or an idea is judged by the effects in practice. Given this orientation, it is less surprising that the entire Renaissance would fail to produce a philosophical system of the highest order. And the conservatism toward intellectual freedom, in its extreme form, would lead finally to the persecution of witches and the Inquisition. But the emphasis on achievement and palpable success animated the monumental creations in art and architecture for which the age will be remembered.

If the Gothic cathedral has that ambiguous and ethereal character of a Platonic idea, the Renaissance city displays the orderly reasonableness of Aristotle's categories. But there is no contradiction in identifying Petrarch with both. He sought to remove belief from the context of philosophical debate but, at the same time, to restore the citizen to a life of participation and achievement of the sort proclaimed by the ancients. In separating, or seeking to separate, philosophy from religion and in striving to give the former a practical function, he was instrumental in furthering the late medieval development that would ultimately flower as the experimental science of Galileo. His attacks on Aristotle were not of philosophical consequence; most of the anti-Aristotelianism of the Renaissance is less than commanding in its comprehension of Aristotle's works. They were, however, of general intellectual consequence. The authority of the Aristotelians, by the fourteenth century, had begun to retard and even repress philosophy and science. There is a general impression, though one not without severe limitations, that the modern world did not begin until this authority was overcome. To the very limited extent that this is true, Petrarch figures centrally.

Architecture speaks as directly for the spirit of an age as do its words. We need only compare the disciplined, line-and-angle proportions of the Renaissance palace with the free, "barbaric" imperfections of the Gothic cathedral. Without denying the beauty of either, or insisting that one is superior to the other, we still recognize a vanity, a pretense, even a showmanship in the Renaissance structures when examined against the herculean innocence of a Chartres or a Mt. St. Michel. This distinction was first examined by John Ruskin, who played so important a part in the "Gothic revival" in Victorian England. We might develop a more complete understanding of the departure the Renaissance represents and of the variety of conservatism for which Petrarch spoke by recalling Ruskin's analysis. In what he has to say about the Gothic and the

"Manufacturing Consent"
Noam Chomsky

Victorian Gothic revival
conservatism

late or "High" Renaissance, Ruskin summarizes the truisms of an age and conveys at once that sense of living freedom and the residuals of that earlier age of the living metaphor:

Of servile ornament, the principal schools are the Greek, Ninevite, and Egyptian; but their servility is of different kinds. The Greek master-workman was far advanced in knowledge and power above the Assyrian or Egyptian. Neither he nor those for whom he worked could endure the appearance of imperfection in anything; and, therefore, what ornament he appointed to be done by those beneath him was composed of mere geometrical forms . . . which could be executed with absolute precision by line and rule. . . . The Assyrian and Egyptian, on the contrary, less cognizant of accurate form in anything, were content to allow their figure sculpture to be executed by inferior workmen, but lowered the method of its treatment to a standard which every workman could reach, and then trained him by discipline so rigid, that there was no chance of his falling beneath the standard appointed. . . . The workman was, in both systems, a slave. . . . The third kind of ornament, the Renaissance, is that in which the inferior detail becomes principal, the executor of every minor portion being required to exhibit skill and possess knowledge as great as that which is possessed by the master of the design; and in the endeavor to endow him with this skill and knowledge, his own original power is overwhelmed, and the whole building becomes a wearisome exhibition of well-educated imbecility. . . . But in the medieval, or especially Christian, system of ornament, this slavery is done away with altogether; Christianity having recognized, in small things as well as great, the individual value of every soul. . . . It seems a fantastic paradox, but it is nevertheless a most important truth, that no architecture can be truly noble which is not imperfect. And this is easily demonstrable. For since the architect, whom we will suppose capable of doing all in perfection, cannot execute the whole with his own hands, he must either make slaves of his workmen in the old Greek . . . fashion, and level his work to a slave's capacities, which is to degrade it; or else he must take his workmen as he finds them, and let them show their weaknesses together with their strength, which will involve the Gothic imperfection, but render the whole work as noble as the intellect of the age can make it.⁹

Marsilio Ficino (1433–1499) and Hermeticism

Ficino is of interest because he was selected by Cosimo de' Medici to lead the newly established Platonic Academy in Florence (1462). Renaissance Plato-

nism, which was never a re-creation of pure, Platonic philosophy, was yet one more movement or attitude that served to challenge the authority of Aristotelianism. It is important to continue to refer to the contrary perspective or "the enemy" as Aristotelianism and not Aristotle, for much of the criticism and scorn displayed toward Aristotle was based on a failure to comprehend the philosopher's system. Moreover, the attempt to prove rationally God's existence and the ultimate nature of nature itself was a Scholastic attempt and one fashioned from Aristotle's methods and arguments; it was not undertaken by Aristotle in the same way, nor was Aristotle as confident that the realms of society, politics, biology, or psychology would fit neatly into a logical framework.

In addition to installing Ficino as director of his new academy, Cosimo de' Medici kept him busy by providing a steady infusion of Greek manuscripts to be translated. He was no more insistent regarding any of these than he was in the case of the *Corpus Hermeticum*, a collection of books thought to contain the pre-classical and mystical secrets of the disciples of Hermes. Tradition had it that Hermes descended directly from Zoroaster and that his genealogical successors included Orpheus, Aglaophemus, and Pythagoras himself. Thus, the "divine" Plato's philosophical inspiration derived initially from Egyptian mystery religions and only these possessed the purest theology. Ficino titled his translation of the *Corpus* "Pimander," and it became one of the most widely read and influential manuscripts of the period. Among its most devout patrons was Giovanni Pico (see below). It was even greeted tolerantly by Pope Alexander VI.¹⁰

The Renaissance love of antiquity was based in part upon the general belief that the purest and most philosophical eras had been those of Greece and Rome and that, from that time onward, civilization had undergone steady deterioration. Added to this linear perspective on virtue was the suspicion that if one could penetrate history even further back, beyond Athens and Rome to the very fountains of Greek wisdom, one would find the absolute essence of spiritual energy. Egypt always held a deep fascination for the Renaissance faithful, and the *Pimander* unleashed a wave of Egyptomania. The Hermes legend, which the seventeenth-century scholar Isaac Casaubon proved to be authored by various hands between 100 and 300 A.D., came to dominate the spiritual aspects of Renaissance life. By deftness of interpretation and through agile translation, Ficino was able to establish a nearly perfect compatibility between its central themes and those of the New Testament. More encouraging even than this surprising agreement was the possibility held out by the *Corpus Hermeticum* that the individual in this life could command supernatural powers and share in the Cosmic spirit. The Egyptian priests had unearthed all the necessary chants, had discovered all the secret astrological configurations, and had documented the most reliable number combinations and alphabetical series. They had divined

Egyptian

all the essences, talismans, foods, and ceremonies. Those experienced in their ancient art could summon the forces of heaven and partake in the Oneness. It was Hermetism that placed the sun at the center of cosmic concern, allowing the earth to move, a principle duly acknowledged by Copernicus in defense of his seemingly odd speculations which were to the same effect. It was this same mystical wisdom that accorded the magus (a kind of magician) the status of a priest. Finally, it was a fundamental tenet of the Hermetic gospel that man is an agent of change, a rational-spiritual force capable of altering nature's course. That human dignity of which Pico wrote so movingly we now recognize as indebted to the Hermetic revival. It proved to be a boon as well for alchemy, for the new (Copernican) astronomy, and for a good share of what passed for science from the sixteenth to the seventeenth century. Giordano Bruno's vaunted defense of Copernicanism was, in the last analysis, no more than Hermeticism, bearing little relation to the scientific merits of the case. In addition, many of the most ardent assertions about the human will and dignity were made by those firmly rooted in the new Hermetism. Indeed, the Renaissance focus upon the will itself is, in considerable measure, inspired by lessons from the *Pimander*.

Ficino would write in a separate work that man is something of a god; one who rules over animals, who provides for both the living and the lifeless, who instructs others.

It is also obvious that he is the god of the elements, for he inhabits and cultivates all of them. Finally, he is the god of all materials, for he handles, changes, and shapes all of them. He who governs the body in so many and so important ways, and is the vicar of the immortal God, he is no doubt immortal.¹¹

Ficino distinguished between two kinds of magic; one practiced by those who merge with demons through religious rituals, and the noble sort practiced "by those who seasonably subject natural materials to natural causes."¹² Even among these there are mere inquisitive types who show off with ostentatious tricks. But there is also the necessary form of natural magic joining medicine with astrology and as compatible with scripture as it is essential to the development of knowledge.

As with so many facets of Renaissance life and thought, these lines from Ficino and the Hermeticism they express preserved the worst of what was old and promoted the best of what was to be the new. Hermeticism, with its brooding chants, its nonsensical astrological and dietary hocus pocus, and its ritual fever, kept some of the best minds of the period and most of the plain folks under the heaviest cowls of superstition and fear. The witchcraft of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries is partly its legacy, as were the rites and tortures invented to solve the problem. Great artists were inspired by Hermetic

tenets; others were driven to depravity by the same tenets. In his way, Ficino exemplifies these several and finally incompatible tendencies and certainties. The competing alternatives of Nature and Spirit were implicit in the Hermetic system. Part of this system, through the development "natural magic," led ultimately to an interest in experimental science and Francis Bacon's recipes for the manipulation of nature. The other part, through "spiritual magic," was matched with the macabre banalities of exorcism, witch-hunting, and self-mutilation.

Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (1463–1494)

One of the more durable characteristics of that form of humanism advanced by the Florentines of the Renaissance was optimism. The leading spokesmen of the period were all infected with the idea of progress. They saw themselves as agents of change, and this, after all, is the dominant element in the idea of freedom. Perhaps no one was more coherent in his assertion of this idea or more persuasive in bringing it to the foreground of Renaissance discourse than Giovanni Pico. His *Oration on the Dignity of Man*¹³ establishes the human community as unique, even by heavenly standards! It is in this essay that Pico thanks God for granting to humans the freedom to change that even the angels do not possess. He notes that animals are tied to their instincts, mindlessly fulfilling the prescriptions of their species. The angels, enjoying a state of spiritual perfection, dedicate themselves eternally and immutably to the praise of God. Man, however, being neither instinctive nor perfected, is free to move in either direction; to degenerate to purely instinctual and sensual levels of existence, or to rise, through reason, to a nearly angelic station:

If sensitive, he will become brutish. If rational, he will grow into a heavenly being. If intellectual, he will be an angel and the son of God. . . . Who would not admire this, our chameleon?¹⁴

Here, then, is one reply to Ficino's conservative neo-Platonism and hereditarianism. Indeed, man is "stamped" by God in such a way as to be predisposed, but it is freedom to which he is predisposed. God has not limited man in that dire, constitutional way suffered by animals:

On man when he came into life the Father conferred the seeds of all kinds and the germs of every way of life.¹⁵

The notion expressed here has a modern equivalent in Haeckel's maxim, "Ontogeny recapitulates phylogeny": each advanced species progresses through the developmental stages of the less advanced on its way to maturity. Pico was not, of course, advancing an embryological theory but a psychological one: as individuals confront the challenge of life, they can use reason and

intellect, thereby improving and developing these, or they can confine themselves to the more primitive apparatus of survival shared with lower forms of life. Pico, persuaded that all philosophical systems finally agree on certain principles, insists that the only really human life for human beings is one in which devotion, experience, action, and contemplation, are combined by the powers of reason. He does not reject Ficino; he assimilates his arguments. He does not shun the skeptic; he engages him in debate. He does not deny the Stoic immutability of natural law; he merely excludes man from its reach. To the cynic who points accusingly at philosophers' inability to agree, Pico insists that Plato and Aristotle, Scotus and Thomas, Avicenna and Averroes, when properly understood, were in substantial agreement and never contradicted each other on fundamental matters.¹⁶

In addition to his direct influence, Giovanni Pico indirectly influenced Renaissance scholarship through his nephew and biographer, Gianfrancesco Pico della Mirandola (1469–1533). Perceiving his uncle as hero and genius, Gianfrancesco was not, however, attracted by the *pax philosophica* so earnestly desired by Giovanni. In his *Examen Vanitas Doctrinae Gentium* (1520), he unleashed an attack on Aristotle which, in its tone and interpretive deficiencies, served as a model for the next two centuries of anti-Aristotelianism.¹⁷

Nature and Spirit

It is constructive to treat the two Picos together because they demonstrate the special, intellectual contradictions of the Renaissance and because these contradictions anticipated many of the psychological and social characteristics of the Reformation. The history of discourse on the human character may be summarized under two great headings: "Nature" and "Spirit." Beneath the former we find naturalism, Stoicism, materialism, and, ultimately, scientific determinism and logical positivism. Below the latter are the near opposites of these: spiritualism, idealism, transcendentalism, psychological indeterminism, and Romanticism. Every century or so the balance changes but the essential positions remain stubbornly constant. In the Hellenistic period, the controversy was over the reality of the Platonic Ideas. Among the Scholastics, this controversy surfaced in the form of the nominalist-realist antagonism. In the individualistic climate of the Renaissance, it becomes a battle between neo-Platonists and Aristotelians. In the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries the terms of conflict are "empiricism" and "idealism."

For the better part of five hundred years the method of analysis introduced to settle these disputes was logic and, more particularly Aristotle's forms of demonstrative proof. Nature was to be described according to the *Categories*, and the truths of nature were to be unearthed and preserved through the infallibility of the syllogism. The Aristotle of the *Historia Animalium* and other naturalistic works was either ignored or never found. Thus, Aristotle the ratio-

nalist dominated scholarship, while Aristotle the ethologist and empiricist enjoyed only the fleeting recognition of a Grosseteste, a Roger Bacon, a Duns Scotus.

From the earliest decades of the Patristic period theologians expressed concern for the intellectual hegemony Aristotle was coming to exercise over the new faith. Tertullian, with his Jovian impatience, dismissed the philosopher as a mere pagan. Plotinus read him as if he were something of an Epicurean. With Augustine's *Meditations*, Plato becomes the ancient of record, receiving first honors, but philosophy itself is relegated to a secondary position on matters of religious importance. The rediscovery of Aristotle in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries not only raised challenges to the authority of Platonism but led to such a veneration of Aristotle that his works soon served to arbitrate even questions of Scripture. By the fifteenth century the faith that Thomas Aquinas had sought to defend through rational analysis aided by Scripture had become, in many learned quarters, a mere branch of logic and rhetoric. Within the fifteenth-century Florentine circles, we discover several scholarly movements: (1) the revival of Platonism as a system, promising to overcome Aristotelianism; (2) a renewed Aristotelianism equipped to meet these neo-Platonist attacks; and (3) Giovanni Pico's *syncretism*, by which all philosophical perspectives are searched for truth and assimilated, peacefully, into a grand Christian scheme. To these we add a fourth movement which, while it employed the scholar's traditional tools, was not scholarly in conception or in its mission. This was the anti-intellectual movement away from books, away from argument, away from analysis, away from proof. In its sincerest expression it was led by Girolamo Savonarola's ceremonial "burning of the vanities." In its meanest form, it was led by the mob that burned Savonarola himself. Between the extremes of piety and hate stand the efforts of such sober commentators as Lorenzo Valla and Gianfrancesco Pico: the former found enough contradictions among the pagan philosophers to dismiss all of them in favor of simple Christian faith; the latter read Aristotle with such distorting lenses as to convert Aristotelianism into a Lockean form of empiricism and then set out to dismiss the philosopher because the senses are less than perfect!

It was in the fifteenth century that the Church was able to cement its position politically. Concurrently, it found it necessary to cement its doctrines as well. Scholasticism had never been more than the gospel of an intellectual elite. Within its fraternity, only Ockham toyed with heresy. By the Renaissance, however, the secular branch was not only more educated and powerful than it had been since the second century, but was increasingly at odds with the Church over economic and military issues. Philosophical disputes were no longer mere academic exercises. In a word, philosophy had become relevant. One moved through crowded Florence confronting a wave of street-corner philosophers peddling a variety of interpretations, all documented with quips and quotes, even if few bore any close connection to ancient wisdom. Ideas had

become politicized and intellectuals had become warriors. The authorities, both secular and clerical, agreed to determine truth in their own special manner, and in 1478 the Spanish Inquisition was launched. For two hundred years Nature and Spirit would do battle: Nature, according to which man's dignity is a matter of record, his reason and power nearly limitless, his body and his artifices beautiful, his life and his city reasonable, and his mind inquiring; Spirit, with its extra-terrestrial vision, its sense of wonder and fear, and its murky and ascetic renunciations.

The Renaissance has left unambiguous records of this useless but ageless conflict. Nature and naturalism, in their historic marriage to empiricism and materialism, are expressed equally in the art, architecture, and political organization of the Renaissance city and in the ruthless and terrifyingly reasonable exploitation of the weak, the dull, and the poor. Renaissance naturalism simultaneously elevated geometry to the level of aesthetics and developed corruption and deceit to the level of a science. The Aristotle of the *Metaphysics* could be used to justify my success and your failure on the basis of that unavoidable final cause toward which all our actions proceed. The Aristotle of the *Politics* and Plato's philosopher-king now made Machiavelli's Prince almost syllogistically necessary.

The poor and the ignorant, important to any age because of their numbers and their labors, were now compressed into bustling and prospering cities; they now had firsthand knowledge of what they were missing. Not since the Augustan period had the lowest classes been so close and in such constant commerce with the educated and affluent elite. Serving at the Banquet of Reason, these plain people could not help but pick up many small but fascinating morsels: human dignity of man, freedom of the will, final causes, necessary truths. All heady notions, indeed. Unfortunately, these leftovers mixed poorly with Spirit and spirituality. Final causes and necessary truths, when digested by those used to simpler fare, create the sense of predestination and inevitability. Thus the doctrines of Spirit, which helped to mold some of the most sainted, pious, and loving people in all the world, also bred terrified souls, looking for a witch to burn, a prophesy to fulfill, an astrological sign that would disclose their fate. Renaissance spiritualism reached the summit of the Christian ideal and sank to the depth of fanaticism.

The contradictions within and between those movements we have identified as Nature and Spirit would come to determine the diverging paths taken by philosophers in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries and by psychologists in the nineteenth.

Piety Reaffirmed: Luther and Savonarola

We are not concerned directly with theological claims and disputes and, if we were, Martin Luther and Girolamo Savonarola surely could not be treated un-

der the same heading. Nor, to be sure, is it warranted to accuse either of them for those pietistic reactions to the new learning that led ultimately to the most scandalous forms of oppression and censorship. At one level, the two had several things in common. Both came from working-class families, both were priests, and both were gifted students and avid readers of the classics early in life. Both were passionately opposed to luxury, pomp, and privilege. Both were defiant and belligerent. Neither gained materially from the fame he won. Both were God-fearing Christians without a skeptical bone in their bodies. But there was, at a still deeper level of their being an additional similarity: Luther and Savonarola were overcome by and devoted their lives to promoting a mystical sense of life's meaning, and each, in his own way, instilled in the masses an intense hostility for all the trappings of what history recognizes as high civilization.

Savonarola's contempt for the Medicis was without limit or embarrassment. His rhetorical skill and his exemplary life escalated him to the position of de facto dictator of Florence, where in 1497 he led the citizens in the "burning of the vanities." The "vanities" were paintings, books, precious stones, and related symbols of now overly dignified man. He imposed upon his once comfortable clerical brothers a life of severe denial and insisted that this was to be the model for every Christian, popes and princes included. He justified his actions on the basis of Scripture and of direct, divine revelation, the latter permitting him to predict the fate of men and nations. His most vivid inspiration was the apparition of a burning sword commanding him to serve as God's gladiator, a vision amplified by dark voices, clouded skies, and by many other persuasive portents.

Luther, too, was directed to the clerical life by mystical influences, in his case, a terrifying vision. Poor origins and mystical experiences combined with an agile mind to locate him as a professor of theology at Wittenberg, whose Castle Church was to receive his Ninety-five Theses. Like Savonarola before him, he reviled the practice of taxing the poor to enrich the Church. The Theses, in fact were written in direct response to John Tetzel's sale of indulgences, the proceeds of which were to help defray the costs of Julius II's plans for St. Peter's, a work still being carried out in Luther's time under Leo X. But these disputes were only the most superficial aspects of a far more basic rift between Luther and those responsible for the affairs of the Church. At the core of a disagreement that would produce no less than the Reformation itself were competing conceptualizations of Christianity.

Where Luther's theology is rife with complex and subtle elements, his psychology is daringly straightforward. His conception of human nature is completely derivative, where this adjective is intended to contrast with inventive. All he seeks to know about mankind can be found in the New Testament; indeed, most of what he believes can ever be known is given by Paul. In his written debate with Erasmus on the question of free will, he summarizes the

efforts of Greek, Roman, and Scholastic contributions to the issue as instances of the "plagues [Satan] has bred from philosophy." Scripture tells Luther that God's will is the cause of all things, and, therefore, the human will can count for naught. The fatalistic and predestinational refrains dominate his jeering reply to Erasmus,¹⁸ and, in case anyone may be deceived into believing that Luther is just playing the scholar's game, he adds this:

Let me tell you therefore—and I beg you to let this sink deep into your mind—that what I am after in this dispute is to me something serious, necessary, and indeed eternal, something of such a kind and such importance that it ought to be asserted and defended to the death, even if the whole world had not only to be thrown into strife and confusion, but actually to return to total chaos and be reduced to nothingness. . . . Stop your complaining, stop your doctoring; this tumult has arisen and is directed from above, and it will not cease till it makes all the adversaries of the World like mud on the streets.¹⁹

His attack on reason²⁰ is the rhetorical version of the burning of the vanities.

What are the Universities, as at present ordered, but as the Book of Maccabees says: "Schools of 'Greek fashion' and 'heathenish manners' full of dissolute living, where very little is taught of the Holy Scriptures and of the Christian faith, and the blind heathen teacher, Aristotle, rules even further than Christ." Now, my advice would be that the books of Aristotle, the "Physics," the "Metaphysics," "Of the Soul," "Ethics," which have hitherto been considered the best, be altogether abolished. . . . My heart is grieved to see how many of the best Christians this accursed, proud, knavish, heathen has fooled and led astray with his false words. God sent him as a plague for our sins.²¹

Luther's psychology, for which there are generous Patristic precedents, begins with the conviction that man is born in sin. Where the medieval rites of chivalry and the Renaissance opportunities for patronage left room for good works to count in heaven, Luther leaves none: good works cannot be performed by an evil soul, and a good one can be responsible for no evil. In short, until the spirit is clean it is in peril, and there is no public gesture of altruism or grandiosity able to remove this peril. (The so-called Protestant ethic traces back to Luther only in a very circuitous way.) Purification of the soul requires a renunciation of the flesh, and at this point the distinctions to be made between Luther and Plato are less than striking. What is central to Luther's psychology is the will, since our spiritual status can only be assessed in terms of our intentions, and our intentions will either be inspired by God or by Satan. God's inspiration is, alas, grace. Without it, there is no hope; with it, no fear or danger. It will come to those who yearn for it and who, through the mystical effects of Scripture, prepare themselves to receive it. Those in the state of grace are doing

God's work. The rest are sinners, and this latter category is sufficiently wide to embrace popes, bishops, priests, and kings.

On *Christian Liberty* was Luther's inadvertent call to arms.²² It was in this work that he insisted on the essential political freedom of each and every Christian, answerable to God alone and working for God's glory only, a slave to none but the willing servant of all. His message reached a large and eager audience, but when the Peasants' War (1524–1525) erupted, an angry and amazed Luther quickly issued a polemic, *Against the Thievish, Murderous Hordes of Peasants*. If the Renaissance as a whole is an era of contradictions, Luther's life is an apt analogy. His works bristle simultaneously with Dante's conservative awe toward the legitimate monarchy and with Locke's dedication to liberal reform; with Pico's elevating recognition of the worth of every single human life and with that Augustinian sense of the triviality of temporal affairs; with Valla's contemptuous rejection of the Greeks and with his Thomistic penchant for phrasing his case along essentially Aristotelian lines.

Luther did not create the Reformation; he spoke its message. It was the message of an emerging class, one whose power was already hundreds of years old but only recently sensed. For all his intensity, we must conclude that he never realized how far his own spirit of rebellion and reform would take the world when taken up by tens of thousands. In opposing exploitation or fear-mongering he succeeded, like Savonarola, only because he induced even greater fear. He threatened the Church through the masses, and the Church, predictably, threatened the masses. Where his own guide had been reason, he disdained its powers publicly. As reason receded from the arenas of debate, the rack, the stake, and the ax took over.

Psychology and the Witch Trials

The fiercest chapters in the persecution and execution of witches occur between 1400 and 1700. This is after the so-called "dark" and "middle" ages and in centuries including the Renaissance, the Elizabethan Age and the Age of Newton! Nor was the dreadful experience local. There were fewer executions in England (though not Scotland) and in Venice (though not in Italy at large) than in the rest of Europe, but the phenomenon was widespread. The veritable handbook for the interrogation, trial, and punishment of witches was the *Malleus Maleficarum*²³ authoritatively promulgated in 1486 by the Dominican Fathers Heinrich Kramer and Jakob Sprenger, who carefully noted the special procedures that had to be adapted and applied to witch-suspects. But King James I provides an echo of this work in his own *Daemonologie* more than a century later.²⁴ Both works are based on what has come to be called the "witch-theory," a woeful amalgam of ancient legal principles and the developed psychology of the Christian West.

Witches have been a fixture in history and were dealt with legally as early as

Rome's *Twelve Tables*. Often widows or otherwise unattached women, the witches of history have read palms or tea leaves, have given prophesies or herbal remedies or just advice; but they have also threatened with curses, performed what appear to be miracles, and been charged with great harms, including death and the destruction of property. They are prominent in the art and literature of the world, where they have been treated with a mixture of awe, reverence, fear, and loathing.

Prior to the development of religious psychology in the West, the secular law distinguished between "white" and "black" magic as perpetrated by witches, reserving punishment only for the latter (*maleficia*). Witchcraft that was harmless or judged to have desirable consequences was either explicitly unpunished by law or was overlooked by the authorities. In the eastern reaches of the Roman empire and of Christian Europe after Constantine, there was such close and continuing contact with classical Greek science and philosophy that policies were even more enlightened. Witches in these parts of the world (e.g., Syria) were thought of as suffering from just another malady to which we are vulnerable. A "bout of witchery" was not unlike other infections or visitations, and the priestly or monkish *exorcism* was undertaken just as it also was for the treatment of indigestion.

Among the more analytical and metaphysical writers in the West, however, witchcraft posed a problem of great religious consequence: Is the will in fact free or can Satan claim it for himself? If the latter position is taken, then the very moral grounds of earthly and ultimate judgment are shaken, for no one can be regarded as fully responsible. Thus, accepting that witches do indeed have supernatural powers, this power must arise from the witches' voluntary acceptance. Moreover, if this power comes from outside of the order of nature, it can only have either God or the devil as its source. As an evil power, its provenance is no longer a mystery: it is the devil's work. The logic of the case led inexorably to the conclusion that witches derived their powers from an implicit compact, a *pactum implicitum*, with the devil and were therefore guilty not merely of a crime but of *heresy*, for which the punishment was death.

By the time the theory was in place, so, too, were those developed principles of Roman civil law over which all sorts of barbarian tribal customs had overgrown during earlier centuries. As a result, the witch trials featured quite developed procedures for the production and weighing of evidence, for the protection of defendants and the determination of guilt. In the case of witches, some of this was relaxed or suspended. For example, although the law required the identification of those who bring charges against anyone, in the case of witches the identity of accusers was protected lest the witch undertake reprisals.

Torture had long been allowed and even required in Roman laws, as when slaves were to be interrogated. But there was a scrupulous principle in place by

1400 such that there could be no torture in the courtroom itself, and confessions gained through torture had to be repeated at a later time in full view of the court. Nor was it permissible to torture a pregnant woman or to repeat torturous sessions. Virtually none of this, however, availed the women charged as witches. They were tortured repeatedly, and pregnant ones were, at least occasionally, also included. Their accusers remained anonymous. Their loved ones were often presumed guilty of the same heresy, owing to the well-known more or less "infectious" tendencies of witchcraft. *Ha - ...*

In the matter of evidence, there was first confession itself. It is worth recalling that in the vast majority of cases only confessed witches were executed, the execution judged to be not only the right punishment but also a liberation from the pact. Confession was not the only grounds on which verdicts were based, however. There was the famous flotation test: The defendant was placed in a tank of water, held in place by long shafts until she was positioned in the center of the tank, and then left either to sink or float. In the latter case, guilt was presumptive, for the one who is commanded by the devil has greater buoyancy. There was also the "tear-test," which examined the defendant's capacity to cry when regaled with statements about God's love for her and the sacrifice of His only Son for her soul, etc. Failing to cry, she made clear that she had lost the virtue of remorse through her pact with the devil, although James I would caution against being misled by a witches "crocodile" tears. *Spirit*

When, in the sixteenth century, Johann Weyer would offer medical alternatives to the witch-theory—though not denying there were witches—he would note simply that the lighter bones of older women are probably the cause of their floating. It was Weyer's *De praestigiis daemonum et incantationibus ac veneficiis*²⁵ that helped to launch the modern psychiatric perspective on abnormal behavior. The book saw six editions between 1563 and 1583. By this date, such defenders of orthodoxy as Peter Binsfeld, Bishop of Trèves, could still claim that only "a few medical men, advocates of the devil's kingdom" deny that witches have intercourse with the devil, fly in formation to their rendezvous, etc. But Weyer, too, occupies a position of characteristic uncertainty and wandering perspective. He never denied the reality of Satan, nor did he rule out the participation of demons in mental illness. Rather, he considered the weakened mind of the aged and the psychologically distressed to be something of a devil's workshop wherein all varieties of illusion may be crafted. Still, Weyer was concerned with taking the physical evidence into account. Of course women tend to float, given their lighter constitution. To Weyer, this was simply a fact of nature, one known since the time of Hippocrates and lacking in any and all spiritual implications. He observed that drugs such as belladonna, opium, henbane, and tobacco enhanced such effects and could produce them in their own right. Again, forms of mental disorder did not require the participation of occult forces or beings. The poor souls who regard themselves as pos-

essed and admit to being witches are, he reasoned, generally suffering from melancholia. They need the attention of a physician, not an inquisitor.

There were still other scientifically oriented figures struggling to establish a counter to superstitions. Paracelsus (1493–1541) wrote his brief treatise *On Diseases That Deprive Man of Health and Reason*,²⁶ noting in the Preface that the European clergy attribute these diseases to “ghostly beings,” whereas “nature is the sole origin” of them. In this work he would oppose the Galenic theory, adding a medical theory of his own; with all this, however, he still reserved a category, the *Obsessi*, for the devil’s handiwork. Thus, even the enemies of the more radical superstitions were hostages to milder forms themselves.

In the thousands and then tens of thousands of persecutions for this special heresy, there would be many cases in which the powers of the witch or the maladies she allegedly caused were not unlike conditions that might also occur naturally. It was not uncommon in such cases for medical practitioners to be summoned to give advice as to whether the symptoms were natural or not. Among its other contributions to history, then, the witch-phenomenon played a part in introducing medical “expert testimony” into adjudicative deliberations. In the same vein, it became ever more important for those who were actually engaged in studies of nature and natural processes to make clear the difference between their activity and the shady doings of the witch. Thus, in these same centuries we find ever more rhetorical and even defensive claims as to the true nature of scientific study. The borders between natural science and natural magic were not so clear in 1400. If they were clearer in 1600, the inducements of the witch-panic had more than a little to do with the anxious progress in this area.

Reason in Waiting

Thomas Macaulay may well have had Erasmus in mind when he wrote in his *History of England*:

Every where there is a class of men who cling with fondness to whatever is ancient and who, even when convinced by overpowering reasons that innovation would be beneficial, consent to it with many misgivings and forebodings. We find also everywhere another class of men sanguine in hope, bold in speculation, always pressing forward, quick to discern the imperfections of whatever exists, disposed to think lightly of the risks and inconveniences which attend improvements, and disposed to give every change credit for being an improvement. In the sentiments of both classes there is something to approve but, of both, the best specimens will be found not far from a common frontier.²⁷

Erasmus can be grouped with Savonarola and Luther to this extent: he was a reformer, an enemy of clerical abuse. Moreover, like the older Savonarola and the younger Luther, he was a scholar whose inspiration was grounded in Scripture. Here, however, the similarities end abruptly. Erasmus was a man of universal genius whose rare capacities would have surfaced in any age and under any circumstances. Those affairs of life and of state to which he directed his genius are neither national nor seasonal. Luther himself noted as early as 1517, in a letter to John Lang, that Erasmus could not be counted on to further Luther's objectives because "for him human considerations have an absolute preponderance over divine."²⁸

In many relevant respects the Renaissance was more of a "middle" age than its predecessor. It was the interim separating two millennia, one ancient and one modern. The burning question put to the best minds of the sixteenth century was whether one period could gently give way to the next or whether the new could arrive only upon the death of its parent. Erasmus, more than any other figure of the period, hoped and worked for the first of these possibilities, and failed. Failure was inevitable. His time was one of desperation, foment, intrigue, and unrelenting enmity. His temper was one of conciliation, wit, urbanity, and graciousness. We appreciate his merits more adequately by realizing that as he wrote witches were being burned, astrologers were revered, and elixers concocted to rid the body of daemonic possession. Among the scholars of the day, invective and solemnity had all but replaced the search for truth. Europe was dividing itself between king and pope, between reason and passion, between obedience and revolution. Erasmus tried to hold these together, knowing all the while that it simply couldn't be done.

If Luther may be said to have had a scriptural conception of human nature, Erasmus must be said to have had an Erasmian view. To avoid this tautology is to court inaccuracy, for the Erasmian view is *sui generis*. That his conception was Christian can be admitted only if we recall his devotion to "St. Socrates." That his position on fundamental questions of faith was orthodox may be granted as long as we note his sympathy for the Skeptics,²⁹ not to mention his charming reproach of theologians in *The Praise of Folly*.³⁰ There was none more learned in Greek or Latin nor any more eager to promote classical letters but, unlike the Florentine Graecophiles who had gone past respect to adoration, Erasmus was wholesomely critical even of the most celebrated of ancient writers. His admiration of Lorenzo Valla³¹ was based in large measure on Valla's willingness to scorn the ancients when they earned it.

Erasmian psychology is common-sense psychology, at once practical and eclectic. It flies off every page of his *Colloquies*, the little works rewarded doubly by being condemned both by the Faculty of the Sorbonne and the Council of Trent.³² Of special interest are those dealing with exorcism and alchemy. Not only are these twins of gloomy nonsense held up to ridicule but they are

presented in such a way that to hold out any validity for either is to proclaim oneself an innocent. Perhaps the best of the lot is the one titled "Charon," from the Greek mythological ferryman who brought the souls of the deceased across the river Styx. The colloquy is between Charon and Alastor, the latter querying Charon on the nature of his cargo, and on the varied problems confronted by one with a job such as his. Erasmus stages the colloquy in order to display the banality of war, especially that so-called "just war," and to depict the shabby rationalizations invented by zealots to justify what is finally homicide. Charon complains that the forests have gone bare feeding wood to witch-burners. Alastor asks if it is true that the souls of Frenchmen and Spaniards are rather light! He then observes that many a bishop, whose life would not have amounted to much at all, grows rich and famous in time of war: "They make more profit from the dying than the living."³³

In *The Alchemist*, the master of the art, "who knows no more about it than an ass," is no more than a swindler who wins his way into the greedy heart of a great University scholar. In *A Pilgrimage for Religion's Sake*, another simpleton is presented, this one believing that the Virgin Mary has sent him a note complaining of the requests she receives from gamblers, loose women, and so forth. He knows the letter is authentic because the handwriting matches that which wrote "venerabilis" on Venerable Bede's epitaph. And so, one by one, Erasmus pricks vanity, exorcises exorcism, gleefully laments superstition, and otherwise reminds us of our duty to the simple lessons of saintly lives and of the extent to which all the trappings invented to decorate such lives serve only to obscure them.

Erasmus was neither scientist nor philosopher. He was not a dramatist or a statesman as these ranks are customarily claimed and awarded. He was a judicious observer, and, by this very fact, he pleaded the case for nature. His letters, colloquies, essays, and adages spoke directly of the observable world—of its problems, its charlatans, its warmongers, its vanities, its follies. His works reflected not only the labors of a polished mind and sympathetic heart but the precision and objectivity earned by judgments when good sense, opened eyes, and freedom from cant address the universe. He was the noblest side of Renaissance humanism.

Leonardo da Vinci (1452–1519)

In his *De Divisione et Utilitate Scientiarum* ("On the Division and Utility of the Sciences"), Savonarola accorded first place to philosophy and, revealingly, the lowest rung to ethics, economics, and politics. But can we believe that this was his genuine position? Can we believe, that is, that one of the most potent political forces in Renaissance Florence, a man who made a mockery of the classical writings, actually held philosophy in the highest regard and politics in the lowest? In the same work, we are reassured to discover that it is theology

that is the ultimate science and that all the others are subsidiaries. Thus, when we read Savonarola's little treatise carefully, we note that philosophy is first among the servants of theology and that the latter, notwithstanding the rigors of Scholastic analysis, is fundamentally spiritual.

Of the records left by the Renaissance, perhaps it is the paintings that offer the clearest evidence of the beliefs and attitudes of the era. The texts of the age are helpful, but, owing to the censorship exercised over the written word, they are often of uncertain credibility. Contrast Savonarola's confusing classification of philosophy with Raphael's fresco *The School of Athens*, painted about 1509. Center stage is given to Plato and Aristotle, around whom are arranged seven liberal arts. This work captures the distinctively Scholastic flavor of Renaissance scholarship at least as effectively as any tract written by Valla, Pico, or Ficino. Raphael leaves no doubt in the viewer's mind: human creations fit neatly into categories; the categories complement each other but do not overlap; human invention appears in different degrees and one degree is more valued and true than a lower one; and philosophy (metaphysics), as Aristotle said, is the Queen.

Art historians have properly found significance in Raphael's inclusion of painting among the notables in this fresco. The inclusion is prima facie evidence of the status achieved by the artists of the Renaissance and of their clear awareness of this status. But what is all the more apparent in this work, and there are literally hundreds of others that make the same point, is that the Renaissance mind, when it searched for the eternal truths, produced Scholastic solutions. It is precisely because of this that the only alternative for many of the Renaissance anti-Aristotelians was to reject all philosophy. Metaphorically we may say that the Renaissance scholar could examine the world through one of only two spectacles: either of philosophy, and this meant Scholasticism; or of theology, and this meant spiritualism. To escape the categories meant to leave nature altogether, for what was "nature" other than quantity, quality, substance, state, and position. If we are to contrast the truly exceptional philosophical minds of the Renaissance with the large Scholastic background, we begin by noting that Erasmus and Leonardo da Vinci, through superficially different media of expression, escaped the categories and did not abandon nature.

It is always hazardous to rest a case on a single work, let alone a single paragraph. Nonetheless, if one were called upon to locate a brief statement within the corpus of Renaissance thought, a statement that completely anticipated the modern era, the following from Leonardo's *Book on Painting* could hardly be surpassed:

Many will think they may reasonably blame me by alleging that my proofs are opposed to the authority of certain men held in the highest reverence by their inexperienced judgments; not considering that my

works are the issue of pure and simple experience, who is the one true mistress. These rules are sufficient to enable you to know the true from the false—and this aids men to look only for things that are possible and with due moderation—and not to wrap yourself in ignorance; if this has no good result, you would have, in despair, to give yourself up to melancholy.³⁴

And, again, in his essay on physiology:

Though human ingenuity may make various inventions which, by the help of various machines, answer the same end, it will never devise any invention more beautiful, nor more simple, nor more to the purpose than Nature does.³⁵

With respect to the soul, he retains this same, modest naturalism, leaving “to the imagination of friars, those fathers of the people who know all secrets by inspiration,”³⁶ the question of the soul’s spiritual composition. For his own part, he will eat no meat, cause no animal to suffer, his ethics being as basic as his natural philosophy and clearly tied to it.

Leonardo wrote on the full range of scientific and engineering topics that would be the focus of attention for centuries. Many of his ideas and inventions would not be improved upon until our own time. His anatomical sketches can still be used for instruction in biology, just as his drawings of various devices can still inform the mechanical engineer. His genius as inventor and painter is so widely recognized and discussed that we need not tarry to revere it. In matters that came to be of importance to modern psychology, his greatest contributions were in the field of visual perception. He explored and developed the geometric principles of perspective and, in the process, defined the conditions necessary for depth perception. He studied as well the factors conducive to illusions, to distortions of apparent size, to color contrast, to brightness-enhancement at boundaries, and to the perception of motion. His outlook was one of undaunted empiricism and his methods of inquiry followed accordingly. He shared with Aristotle the conviction that all knowledge begins with perception. To use his words, “wisdom is the daughter of experience.”³⁷ He was duly respectful of reason, a capacity he enjoyed bountifully, but was unalterably opposed to the form of rationalism that required a rejection of the facts of experience. Reason and sense, for Leonardo, were conversant with different features of the knowable world, the former providing the certain truths of mathematics, the latter yielding the probable causes of natural events. He distrusted any science devoid of mathematical substance, and he argued that any science, in its final stage of development, would be mathematical in form. This smacks of Cartesian science and also allows us to locate Leonardo, as a theorist, in the rationalist tradition. However, in requiring that the scientific work

with the clear and immediate evidence of sense before attempting to "mathe-
matize" nature, he was an empiricist of the non-ideological sort.

On the question of human moral dispositions, Leonardo was less than modern, subscribing to an essentially Platonic position. Although willing to attribute failure and vice to bad experience and a lazy attitude, he also believed that people differed in their constitutional makeup: nature made some individuals golden, some brass, and so forth. However, "The greatest deception men suffer is from their own opinions," and this seemed to be a sufficient injunction against excessive theorizing about human psychology. To know man, one must study him the same way one would go about studying anatomy, geography, and mechanics. The method is observational, the perspective naturalistic, the descriptions quantitative. Long before Newton would immortalize experimentalism with the maxim, "Hypothesis non fingo!" ("I frame no hypothesis!"), Leonardo had set the cornerstone.

Was There a Renaissance?

We end this brief analysis of Renaissance philosophical psychology with the question that began it. It is true that the period bracketed by the years 1350 and 1600 yielded no new philosophical system; that the dominant theme in intellectual circles was the one set by the Scholastics; that witchcraft, alchemy, necromancy, persecution, fear, and mysticism were abundant; that the chief concerns and controversies still centered around theological matters; and that the main variable governing political life was the ageless quest for power. But it is also true that a strong and growing middle class began to assert itself; that skepticism was diffused more widely; that literacy and education extended to greater and greater numbers; that art and architecture of unprecedented appeal were created; that science and engineering attained a status not enjoyed since antiquity; and that man and his planet were, in increasing fashion, assimilated to that system of thought we have called naturalism. Intellectual epochs, as we have said so often, do not begin and end abruptly. While Leonardo preached the value of empiricism and experimentalism, Calvin was contributing predestinationism, and Calvin's following was a good deal larger than Leonardo's.

To the extent that there is an irreconcilable antagonism between naturalism and spiritualism, the Renaissance is important as a period in which the options and obligations held out by each were made clear and pressing. Reading Calvin and Erasmus transports one back to Athens, to the spare and righteous life recommended by the Pythagoreans and the reasonable, cheery gospel of Anaxagoras. As the Catholic Church began to suffer from divisive pressures, various sects splintered away and ironically strived for a condition of spiritual life much like the one founded by the early fathers of Christianity itself. We do not underestimate the sincerity or intelligence of either the reformers or the ortho-

dox in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries to note the similarity between their convictions and those that once divided Plato and Aristotle, or Augustine and Aquinas, or Pythagoras and Anaxagoras. Nor do we trivialize their concern by observing the frequency with which it has been expressed and defended historically. In every age there are those who find excesses in the material conditions of life and who seek to rescue us from these by recommending or imposing blind obedience, discipline, denial, and humility. If they succeed, it is not long before still others perceive that human life must amount to more than these; that people must do what they can do; that happiness, a sense of dignity, and a means of personal growth and individual achievement are as essential as food and shelter; that nature is what it appears to be; and that what does not appear, alas, is not.

The Renaissance featured a rebirth of intellectual independence, too, which allowed secular knowledge to develop and be promulgated. The birth of public universities as early as the twelfth century in Italy not only extended higher learning beyond the walls of the abbey but also established practical subjects as appropriate topics for study and debate. The University of Padua was central to this movement. It was here that Pomponazzi rekindled Aristotelianism not as the foundation of theology but as the essential ingredient of naturalism and of any systematic approach to the human condition. As Professor Wade has observed:

In analyzing his [Pomponazzi's] works . . . the modern historian is struck to see that the five problems with which the Paduan of the Renaissance was preoccupied (existence of God, immortality of the soul, nature of matter, free will, and good and evil, i.e., providence) are the same with which Voltaire struggled at Cirey . . . and strikingly similar to those which engaged the attention of Sartre, Camus, and the other existentialists in the twentieth Century.³⁸

The secular universities, the invention of the printing press, the migration of classicists from fallen Byzantium, the growth of nation-states and their kings as a check on papal authority, the mystical naturalism of the Hermetic truths, and the preceding two centuries of Scholastic intellectualism blended to form a truly original concoction. Where the quest for personal power had once been confined to an aristocratic few, the Renaissance citizens openly sought to make nature work for them; if orthodox, to make it work religiously; if Hermetic, to make it work magically; if humanistic, to make it work in their behalf politically and intellectually. Pragmatism had never been seen on so great a scale, not even in Augustan Rome. Even the fear of the period, its superstitions and mysticism, were pragmatic at the roots. Medicine, which was essentially Arab medicine, reacquainted the Western mind with Averroes in contexts largely

devoid of theological (Scholastic) content. The latent message of Averroist medicine was the message of materialism, and those who absorbed it added to the ranks of naturalism. In the hands of a Pomponazzi, the Averroist form of Aristotelianism led straightaway to a universe of "two truths": the truths of reason nurtured by perception, and the truths of faith revealed by intuition. The latter are beyond proof and therefore need not play a significant role in the affairs of the former. The leading humanists of the period—Erasmus, Thomas More, Montaigne—did not need Averroist science to adopt the same position.

The Renaissance did not succeed in separating Nature and Spirit in a way that might have dignified each. In requiring the two to coexist, Renaissance scholars too often laced each with tenets of the other or talked themselves into believing that each was only a different form of the other. It remained for seventeenth-century philosophers to divorce the two and to promote a notion of irreconcilability which survives to the present day.

The City (Again)

Of the several depressing spectacles allowing the twentieth century to call attention to itself, perhaps that of the modern city is the grayest. Millions of bodies are hurled about daily as they seek shelter and success in the faceless blocks of glass which pass for architecture. It is hardly surprising, then, that each year the historic cities of the Renaissance become more appealing to the pilgrim. Moreover, the appeal is based on something in addition to the exquisite beauty of any given building or any collection of art. It is based as well upon the unmistakable sense of order and proportion conveyed by the city as city. In an important way, it was the Renaissance that invented the idea of a city, at least as that idea survives, though weakly, in our time. The founders of Florence set out to plan a city around definite aesthetic, practical, and political considerations. Not until the fifteenth century did an essentially philosophical vision materialize into conscious urban planning.³⁹ The vision was Leon Battista Alberti's (1404–1472) and its materialization the result of Nicholas V's genius. The latter (1397–1455), as pope, remade Rome. Professor C. W. Westfall reviews the relation between Alberti and Nicholas V this way:

Alberti's theory of architecture and Nicholas's program for papal government flow together. In his testament the pope outlined a purpose for buildings, and in his treatise the architect described the principles of design for such buildings. Buildings that were perpetual monuments to doctrine would also be architectonic structures conjoined into a city that would facilitate the activity of citizens whose love for God moves them to strive for the good through *virtu*. The pope, while governing the Church, would be a stinging *exemplum* of *virtu*, mov-

ing the lower members of the hierarchy to seek God actively. Rome and its buildings would be proper settings for Nicholas's exemplary actions.⁴⁰

The leading architects of quattrocento Rome and Florence were not mere designers. They were, in a manner of speaking, manual philosophers conditioned by Augustinianism to appreciate the city as teacher, the city as a moral agent and moral engine. Here, in the beauty and order of a structurally planned space, men and women and children would be constantly reminded of the obligation to impose beauty and order upon their lives and their wills. In this regard, the Renaissance city is not a sudden invention but the logical extension of the chivalric animus. When communities were scattered and fragile, it was the knight who kept lonely vigil over the human potential for sacrifices and honor. The military and economic security of the Church of quattrocento Italy transformed the idea of city as fortress to that of city as agent. Even with this enlarged set of responsibilities, the city retained an essentially chivalric character. That is to say, even under the more modern press of finance and political machination, the city retained the quality of a symbol—a largely medieval symbol. Where the silhouette of the knight, painted against a drear and portentous sky, once chilled the designs of a luckless felon, once fired the moral passions of children, and once served to imbue peasant and priest alike with the spirit of God's justice and mercy, there now stood the outline of the city. Within its precincts churches and houses, meeting halls and municipal offices, and gardens and markets would be placed according to a plan. Streets would be laid in order to join related functions. Size would be employed as the symbol of significance. Each frieze and corbel not only ornaments a building but tells a story, teaches a lesson, recalls a value, intones an obligation, evokes a noble sentiment. Here is architecture as applied psychology and civics. Florence and Rome in the Renaissance were cities on a grand scale even by modern standards. They were places in which one could find anything known or done by the civilized world. They possessed most of the wealth, nearly all of the art, and the sum of the talent of the age.

There is a dark side to all of this, too. Ancient Greece hosted a symbiotic arrangement between aristocrat and farmer. At the height of Athenian influence, the agricultural class still played a salient role in the affairs of state. The medieval township or fortress-community preserved this tradition. Even the Roman patrician revered the land and sought the pastoral reaches of the exurban territory for peace and reflection. The Renaissance city, however, as a valid city, began to change this, and the change has progressed almost without a pause. By the fifteenth century, the needs of major cities have already begun to be insatiable. The countrysides become mere suppliers; their inhabitants, near-barbarians. Now, urbanism, urbanity, is the culture, and the city is at once a

symbol of some higher mission and a reality in its own right. That is, the possibilities the city once announced are now obscured by the realities it presents to its citizens. Living becomes coping, and the quest for perfection gives way to the struggle for success. The chivalric ideal becomes perverted into the gaudy ritual of self-conscious heroism as the knight is displaced by the banker. The city takes on its own life and begins to use and abuse the citizen in return for which it offers mere services. Values give way to fashion, valor to competition, restraint and sacrifice to unimaginable poverty. Understood sociologically, the modern world begins with the Renaissance city, which, ironically, was to reawaken the classical ideal of life.

Notes

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6. *Ibid.*, p. 75.
7. *Ibid.*, p. 103.
8. *Ibid.*, p. 121.
9. John Ruskin, *The Stones of Venice*, Vol. II, Reuwee, Wattlely and Walsh, Philadelphia, pp. 159–171.
10. Marsilio Ficino, in Cassirer et al., *Renaissance Philosophy of Man*. Regarding its reception, see Frances A. Yates, *Giordano Bruno and the Hermetic Tradition*, University of Chicago Press, 1964.
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13. Giovanni Pico della Mirandola, in Cassirer et al., *Renaissance Philosophy of Man*.
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34. *The Literary Works of Leonardo Da Vinci*, edited by Jean Paul Richte, Vol. I, Phaidon Press, London, 1970, pp. 116–117 (#12).
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39. On the origins of city planning in the fifteenth century, see Carroll William Westfall, *In This Most Perfect Paradise: Alberti, Nicholas V, and the Invention of Conscious Urban Planning*, Pennsylvania State University Press, University Park, 1974.
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2 From Philosophy to Psychology